

Using Our Power to Secure the Peace



AP Photo/Jassim Mohammed

Iraqi soldiers march past a new statue of Iraqi President Saddam Hussein riding a horse, as warplanes fly in formation overhead, during an unexpected military parade Sunday, December 31, 2000, on Baghdad's Grand Celebrations Ground. Iraqi tanks, warplanes, helicopters and missiles were displayed in an apparent show of support for the Palestinian uprising against Israel.

In the fall of 2002, the question of the moment became what to do about Saddam Hussein, president of Iraq. It seemed that Iraq's apparent development of chemical, biological, and nuclear weapons posed a clear and present danger to stability, not just in the Middle East but the world as a whole.

This challenge raised fundamental questions about when we should use our military power to make the world as safe as possible for other peace-seeking countries. In the course of explaining what the United States would do, the Bush administration put forward not just an argument for military actions in response to the Iraqi challenge but a new doctrine, a set of principles for how American military power should be used in the world. The new doctrine is both

an explanation of our intentions as a nation and a guide to future action. It addresses questions about appropriate uses of military power and the role of the international community in enforcing norms of behavior that make the world a secure and productive place to live.

This doctrine is a sharp departure from principles that have guided America's global engagements for half a century. Throughout the Cold War, much of our national defense enterprise rested on the assumption that enemies would not attack us because, by doing so, they would risk provoking an overwhelming retaliatory attack. Would-be attackers were deterred, for fear of what our response would be. Now, in one of the most important shifts in recent history, the present administration's new National Security Strategy supports preemptive attacks against terrorists and against hostile states that have chemical, biological, or nuclear weapons. In other words, we will attack first, if we have reason to think they might attack us. That proposal signals a major change in the uses of American power, and one that is likely to have effects far beyond Iraq. It is part of the response that proponents of our first approach make to the challenge we face as a powerful but less than universally liked — in fact, they say, a threatened — people.

Advocates of this approach feel that because the U.S. now has greater military strength than any nation — and more than most nations working in combination — it can act to keep destructive forces in check. In the twenty-first century, writes military commentator Eliot Cohen, "the U.S. military... has become, whether Americans or others like it or not, the ultimate guarantor of international order." Rather than shrinking from that role, advocates of this approach argue, we need to acknowledge the key role the United States plays and use every means at our disposal to deal with threats to our own security and to world peace. American power is a force for good, they say, not just for our own welfare as a people but that of our allies worldwide.

What Can Be Done ?

Government Actions

- Maintain the U.S. position as the world's only superpower which will require substantial investments in military research and development, and advanced weapon systems.
- Be prepared to act, preemptively and unilaterally if necessary, when hostile states armed with dangerous weapons are prepared to strike against us.
- Reinstate the draft to ensure that there are enough capable recruits to carry out multifaceted U.S. operations.
- Stress our allies to join us in coordinated international efforts to share intelligence information, carry out joint training, and take concerted action against threats of terrorists.

Citizen Actions

- Accept significant commitments of U.S. ground troops on occasion and an increase in American combat casualties as an unavoidable part of those engagements.
- Support reinstatement of the draft as the only fair way of meeting increased needs for military manpower, and be prepared for self, family members and friends to serve if called.
- Accept higher taxes to pay for build-up in the defense budget; and defer ring of domestic projects.
- Anticipate that aggressive action against rogue governments and terrorists may prompt violent reprisals against the United States.

The Indispensable Player

The United States has for years played an indispensable global role. The demise of the Soviet Union ended a massive threat from a single adversary. But in the immediate post-Cold War period the United States responded to a series of smaller but still serious challenges.

In 1991, the United States went to war against Iraq after it invaded its neighbor, Kuwait. If Iraq's occupation of Kuwait had not been challenged, Saddam Hussein would have controlled the huge oil reserves of Iraq and Kuwait. And because of his willingness to use raw power, he would have threatened the even larger oil resources of neighboring Saudi Arabia. By taking the lead in that war and defeating Saddam Hussein, the United States protected its own interests as a major oil consumer and stabilized the entire region. It also led a coalition to defeat aggression on behalf of the world community.

Through the 1990s, the United States conducted bombing raids in

the Balkans as part of a NATO action. American troops served peacekeeping missions in the Middle East and in Yugoslavia. The U.S. confronted North Korea when it was first discovered to be developing nuclear weapons. It worked with the U.N. Security Council to enact sanctions against half a dozen violators of international principles. And American troops took part in humanitarian missions to provide food to starving people in Africa.

In each of these instances, the situations that provoked an American response—aggression, nuclear proliferation, mass starvation, the violation of international agreements—were threats to the kind of world order that Americans value.

These and other U.S. initiatives in the 1990s helped to answer a very practical question: Why should political chaos halfway around the globe be of any concern to the United States and its citizens? The answer, say advocates of this approach, is that U.S. security and prosperity are tightly linked to global stability. Disorder in other areas of the world disrupts trade and investment, increases immigration pressure, jeopardizes access to vital resources, and stimulates other countries to arm themselves. Disorder also makes it easier for terrorists to operate throughout the world. We Americans cannot feel secure in a world where outlaws run free. Evil must be confronted by force.

Paper Tiger

Sometimes a show of force is all that is necessary to quell threatening developments. For example, when the democratically elected government of the Philippines faced an armed coup in 1989, President Bush instructed U.S. fighter



planes to fly over rebel bases. It sent a message to rebels that an overthrow of a democratic government would not be tolerated. The U.S. often has relied on such traditional shows of force to persuade others to do the right thing.

What is striking to advocates of this approach is not America's unsurpassed military strength but our unwillingness to use it and the public's reluctance to support anything other than zero-casualty "surgical strikes."

Thus, after the Gulf War the United States did not forcibly remove Saddam Hussein. Nor did the United States force Iraq to allow U.N. inspectors to operate effectively in the country to assess its capacity for nuclear and biological warfare. After attacks on U.S. embassies in Kenya and Tanzania in 1998, and then again after an attack on the Navy's vessel the U.S.S. Cole in Yemen in October 2000, the U.S. failed to deliver a decisive response, say advocates of this approach.

Only with assertive leadership and aggressive measures when necessary, say advocates of this approach, can America protect its interests and maintain world peace. When the U.S. is reluctant to play this role, instability and conflict increase around the world, eventually arriving at our doorstep. America's enemies are made bolder by our half-hearted actions and our reluctance to use force. To many, the lesson of Vietnam was that the United States should not try to be the world's policeman. The events of September 11 are dramatic proof that we can't afford not to be.

It is essential, say advocates of this approach, not to repeat the mistakes of the 1990s. Nor should we underestimate the difficulties that lie ahead as the United States takes the lead in protecting against dire threats of rogue nations and terrorists.

"At a time like this," writes columnist Charles Krauthammer, "the imprudent ones are those who simply want to lop off one tentacle of the terrorist threat, the one that perpetrated September 11. Doing that will give us satisfaction, a sense of accomplishment, and an entirely false sense of security. The next attack, catastrophic beyond our imagination, is waiting to happen."

Preemptive Unilateral Action

For 50 years, we presumed that our enemies were rational and calculating, unwilling to risk either massive damage or their own self-destruction. Given the kinds of adversaries that we now

face, say advocates of this approach, those assumptions are no longer adequate as a basis for U.S. defense policy. As President Bush put it in a speech at West Point in June 2002, "We cannot defend America and our friends by hoping for the best... If we wait for threats to fully materialize, we will have waited too long... We must take the battle to the enemy, disrupt his plans, and confront the worst threats before they emerge."

We must also, according to this doctrine, prepare to act unilaterally on occasion. Fighting a war as part of a global partnership is, of course, desirable both because of the legitimacy it con-



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fers and as a way to share the burden. However, advocates of this approach say, on various occasions in the past when the United States has tried to fight wars by leading a coalition, the process has turned into a tar pit of indecision.

It is one thing to achieve agreement in the United Nations condemning terrorism, or to pass resolutions like those that require Iraq to disclose, destroy, and abandon all nuclear, chemical, and biological weapons. It is quite another matter to agree on collective action to enforce such resolutions. For the United States, say advocates of this approach, the question is what to do when nations blatantly violate international agreements and thumb their noses at the authority of the United Nations and its resolutions.

Under such circumstances, they say, unilateral U.S. action is the only alternative. The

Romeo was the second of the detonations in Operation Castle. It was, at 11 megatons, the third largest the United States tested. It was the first detonated on a barge. A cone of vapor briefly formed over the mushroom cloud.

essence of responsible global leadership is to do what no other country — or group of countries — is willing to do, and what must be done to thwart a menacing danger. This, they say, is the role America must play in the world of today. As Secretary of Defense Donald Rumsfeld put it, “It’s less important to have unanimity than it is to be making the right decisions and doing the right thing, even though at the outset it may seem lonesome.”

This perspective reflects a stark truth — some leaders are evil and so too are some regimes. In some cases, force is the only answer. We need to be prepared, advocates of this approach acknowledge, for the burden of pursuing this course of action, including the cost of going it alone when necessary without the assistance of allies who share the human costs and the financial burden.

Tradeoffs

The human cost of fighting war may be considerable. Using our military power, not just as a deterrent, but as an active force will lead to casualties, perhaps many of them—both U.S. personnel and numerous civilians in combat areas. There may be need for a draft that disrupts the lives of those drafted, separates families, and does not always seem equitably distributed among eligible Americans. These are factors that the nation needs to prepare for and accept.

War is also costly in sheer financial terms. It is estimated that waging the war in Afghanistan cost the United States up to \$1 billion a month. And this is just the beginning. Each phase of a

continued war on terrorism will involve major expenditures, even by the usual standards of the U.S. military.

Pursuing this course will involve costs of another kind as well. Especially in wartime, U.S. interests require that we maintain close relations with undemocratic governments such as Pakistan and Saudi Arabia.

But the global threats are real, conclude advocates of this approach, and providing for defense and security must come first. It will require deferring some national concerns and scaling down others, at home and abroad. Yet, given the dire threat we face and the fact that only the United States can play this role, it is a necessary commitment, advocates argue, both for the sake of our own security and maintaining the peace globally.

What Critics Say

Secretary of State Colin Powell reflected in his memoirs about his Vietnam tour of duty and what he and other commanders learned from the experience. “Many of my generation . . . vowed that when our turn came to call the shots, we would not quietly acquiesce in half-hearted warfare for half-baked reasons that the American people could not understand or support.” Critics fear that this approach to our global role is likely to lead to another long, costly war like Vietnam that finally ended when American citizens withdrew their support.

This new policy is seriously misguided, say those who oppose this approach, both as a next step in the effort to contain terrorism and as a direction for U.S. actions over the longer term. Far from making the world a safer place, pursuing this course is likely to make the world more dangerous. It is likely to undermine much of what the United States cares about and stands for in the world. And it has the potential to lead us into a swamp of foreign commitments that, over time, will be divisive and sap all of our resources.

This approach misjudges what U.S. military power can accomplish, say critics of this approach. Declaring war on states that sponsor and protect terrorists is a very dangerous undertaking, likely to further enrage those who resent our power. Military action on our part is likely to lead to an endless spiral of violent reprisals.

In particular, say critics, the assertion that the United States must often go it alone by taking

Arlington National Cemetery



unilateral action is dangerously wrong. The essence of world leadership should not consist of insisting on our right to unilateral action because we have more military might than any other nation. It should consist, rather, of using our influence and power to act as leader in building a broad coalition of democratic nations.

New Signals

Far from signaling our intention to go it alone, the United States should renew its commitment to collective action and coordinated international efforts, in part through strong support for the preeminent international institution, the United Nations. Our goal should be to reduce the number of U.S. troops abroad, and to establish a permanent U.N. military force whose task is to protect world peace and stability.

“We are not invulnerable,” writes William Galston, a professor at the University of Maryland’s School of Public Affairs and a former Clinton administration official. “To safeguard our own security, we need the assistance of the allies.... In the long run, our interests will best be served by an international system that is as lawlike and collaborative as possible.”

Using force to strike at other nations that have not attacked is a violation of one of the cardinal principles of the international order, say critics of this approach. The United Nations charter and various decisions of the World Court have prohibited the use of force that is not undertaken in self-defense, unless sanctioned by the U.N. Security Council.

Preemptive attack, say critics, sets a dangerous precedent for other nations. Among nations, as among children on a playground, there is going to be a lot more mayhem once the precedent is established that it is ok for anyone to hit someone else when they think they’re about to get hit. Using our example, India could attack Pakistan, or Israel could feel justified launching preemptive attacks on the Palestinians.

Advocating the right of the Americans to unilateral military action and preemptive attacks, say critics of this approach, is not what we are about. Our role in the world should be to promote the democratic principles and the values this country was founded on, not to act as the world’s policeman.



Indonesian students hold a banner saying “Make Peace Not War” in front of the U.S. Embassy October 24, 2002 in Jakarta Indonesia. About 50 students condemned the Bali bombing and rallied for peace as the U.S. government prepared for a preemptive strike on Iraq as a part of its war on terrorism.

